DENMARK BUSHFIRE BRIGADES WAERN RADIO USE

WAERN Radios

Channels, Talk-Around and your position.

RADIO USER GUIDE

1 WAERN Radios
2 Talking on the Radio
3 Common Radio Issues

Tait vehicle radio

Every vehicle has the yellow head, which runs a VHF high-band and a UHF radio. Where a yellow handset with a display replaces the black one, it adds a second VHF: three radios in all.



Head: VHF + UHF



Handset: 2nd VHF

Change channel	Key the number on the handset, then **Select**. Or ▲ ▼ to scroll, then **Done**.
Swap VHF / UHF	F3 BAND. The large channel on the display is the radio you talk on.
Hear both radios	F1 DUAL MODE once: both channels show, the one you talk on in large type. A second press transmits on both and shows ⇶. Hold F1 for 3 seconds to go back to one radio.
Talk-Around	F4 TALK AROUND: ⇥ shows top left. F4 again, or change channel, to cancel. Only when the IC directs, or if you declare an emergency and get no reply: then ask to be relayed.
Your location	If asked, describe where you are. Give GPS coordinates only if they're requested: **Menu** › [GPS menu item], ▲ ▼ for latitude/longitude or Zone 50 Easting/Northing.
Scan	F2 SCAN. Keep it off at incidents unless the IC directs.

Vertex VX-829 handheld

Black, VHF high band, yellow aerial.



Key lock	Long press the orange button on top to lock or unlock the keys.
Zone knob	1 DEC/PaW 501–553 · 2 WAERN 101–353 · 3 WAERN simplex 354–369 · 4 WAERN 371–400 · 5 DEC/PaW 601–653.
A Talk-Around	Only when the IC directs, or if you declare an emergency and get no reply: then ask to be relayed.
B Power	Normally left as set.
▲ ▼ C Channel	Side keys, or C then the three-digit channel (zones 2 to 4). Change zone first, or after an off/on it may go to an unintended channel.
D Scan	Keep it off at incidents unless the IC directs.
Your location	No GPS. Describe where you are; give coordinates only if requested.
Light on top	Red: transmitting · green flash: busy · yellow flash: selcall.

Use it outdoors, away from the vehicle and obstacles. Not indoors, and not for air operations or as ground controller. On 173 it may hear the repeater but not reach it.

Denmark channels

Tait vehicle radio · VX 3 handheld zone · UHF CB appliance crew

173	Incident command	Tait	**525**	Aerial suppression	Tait
360	Initial command → Sector 1	Tait VX 3	**ESC 220**	Rescue helicopter	Tait UHF
361 · 362	Sector command	Tait VX 3	**CB 1–80**	Farm, graders, tankers, and talk within your crew	Tait UHF UHF CB
358 · 359 · 367	Extra sectors	Tait VX 3			

Sources: DFES aide-memoires and channel guide, Shire of Denmark preformed plan. Tait keys as reprogrammed.

DENMARK BUSHFIRE BRIGADES WAERN RADIO USE

Talking on the Radio

Call signs, prowords and the phonetic alphabet.

RADIO USER GUIDE

1 WAERN Radios

2 Talking on the Radio

3 Common Radio Issues

Making a call

1. **Listen first.** Wait until the channel is clear and you've heard OUT.
2. **Press PTT, wait one second,** then talk.
3. **Call the station you want,** then say THIS IS and your call sign.

OVER My turn is finished. A reply is needed.

OUT Finished, no reply. Only one station says it. Until then, others wait.

EXAMPLE

YOU	"Denmark Chief, this is Shadforth Light Tanker, over."
DENMARK CHIEF	"Shadforth Light Tanker, this is Denmark Chief, go ahead, over."
YOU	"Arrived on scene, two crew, starting on the north flank, over."
DENMARK CHIEF	"Roger, out."

CALL SIGNS DFES lists when they're needed: your first call, a station joining or leaving, changing channel, closing down, difficult conditions and multi-agency incidents. Otherwise they can be left out, as in the example.

Moving off the command channel

Keep 173 for command. At an incident, crews work on simplex: 360 first, then 361 and 362.

1. **"CHANGE TO 360, OVER."** Get ready.
2. **"WILCO, OVER."** Or say if you can't.
3. **"CHANGE NOW, OUT."** Go to 360.
4. **Radio check on 360** straight away.

Common prowords

WAIT	Short pause. Others don't transmit.
ROGER	Message understood. Not a "yes".
CORRECT	Yes, that is right.
CORRECTION	Error. The right version follows.
GRID	Grid reference, digit by digit.
NOTHING HEARD	I called, no reply.
SITREP	What is your situation?
WAIT OUT	Long pause. Others may transmit.
WILCO	Understood, will comply.
SAY AGAIN	Repeat your last message.
I SPELL	Phonetic spelling follows.
RADIO CHECK	How do you hear me?
GO AHEAD	Send your message.
THROUGH ME	I will relay your message.

Phonetic alphabet

Only in poor conditions, for hard-to-catch words, and for critical details such as Forest Grid references. To spell a word, say it, then I SPELL.

A Alpha	**B** Bravo	**C** Charlie	**D** Delta	**E** Echo	**F** Foxtrot	**G** Golf
H Hotel	**I** India	**J** Juliett	**K** Kilo	**L** Lima	**M** Mike	**N** November
O Oscar	**P** Papa	**Q** Quebec	**R** Romeo	**S** Sierra	**T** Tango	**U** Uniform
V Victor	**W** Whiskey	**X** X-ray	**Y** Yankee	**Z** Zulu		

FIGURES **0** zero · **1** wun · **2** too · **3** thuh-ree · **4** fow-wer · **5** fi-yiv · **6** six · **7** se-ven · **8** ate · **9** niner

Sources: DFES Voice Procedures aide-memoire and Field Radio Operator manual; ACP 125(G).

v1.0 · November 2026

DENMARK BUSHFIRE BRIGADES WAERN RADIO USE

Common Radio Issues

And how to fix them: ensuring every message is heard.

RADIO USER GUIDE

1 WAERN Radios

2 Talking on the Radio

3 Common Radio Issues

Hear the examples

1 Hum on the signal

Sounds like a steady low buzz under the voice.

Common cause: a handheld transmitting from its charger, indoors.

IF IT'S YOU

- Lift the handheld out of the charger.
- Step outside, clear of the building.

IF YOU HEAR IT

> **"Loud, distorted. Hum on your signal, over."**

Say "loud and clear" only when it is.

2 Two stations at once

Sounds like a warble or squeal. Neither caller is readable.

Happens after "any station?" and on a busy fireground.

IF IT'S YOU

- Listen before you transmit.
- No reply? You weren't heard. Call again.

IF YOU HEAR IT

> **"Two stations at once. Say again, one at a time, over."**

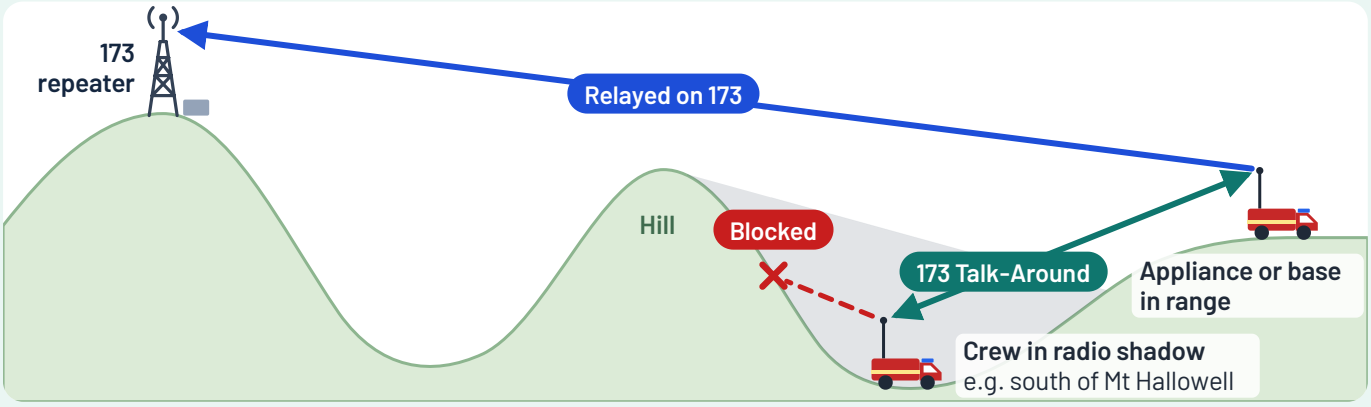
Don't let it pass. Important traffic may be lost.

Report what you hear

Say "clear" only when it is.

STRENGTH	Loud	Good	Weak	Very weak	Fading
READABILITY	Clear	Readable	Distorted	Interference	Unreadable

3 Radio shadow? Use Talk-Around



1. **No reply on 173?** You may be in a radio shadow.
2. **Switch to 173 Talk-Around** and call. Say you're on Talk-Around so they reply on it. Radios on 173 in range hear you direct.
3. **Whoever hears you** answers on Talk-Around, then relays on 173.
4. **Switch back to 173** once you're out of the shadow.